

Programme of Inquiry Review: a seven-step process

How grade-level teams rebuilt a whole school's map of inquiry units so it meets Mexican and U.S. standards and stays balanced across the IB framework.

Who

Every grade-level team, preschool to Grade 5

When

Planning for the 2019–20 school year

My role

Designed and facilitated the process as PYP Coordinator

The problem

Units had to satisfy two national standards systems and the IB framework at once, with no shared way to check coverage.

The approach

Break the review into seven focused tasks that every team completes in the same order, moving from standards to IB balance to planning.

The outcome

A revised, vertically aligned Programme of Inquiry with standards-mapped unit planners for every grade.

Phase A: Standards

Are we teaching everything we're required to teach?

1

Science and social studies coverage

Teams review Mexico's national (SEP) and U.S. science and social studies standards against the year's units.

Result: every required standard is placed in a unit.

2

Literacy and math integration

Teams map SEP and U.S. literacy and math standards (Common Core) into each unit.

Result: reading, writing, and math are woven into inquiry, not taught apart from it.

Phase B: IB framework

Is each unit a strong inquiry, and is the year balanced?

3

Central ideas and lines of inquiry

Teams review and strengthen each unit's central idea and lines of inquiry.

Runs across two sessions.

Result: clearer, more conceptual units.

4

Balance audit

Teams check that key concepts, learner profile attributes, and approaches to learning are all covered, and none overused.

Result: a balanced year, checked with the Grade Level Balance tool.

5

Vertical alignment

Teams use the IB theme descriptors to compare units across grades for each transdisciplinary theme.

Result: each theme builds from one grade to the next.

Phase C: Planning

How will the year actually run?

6

Order of units

Teams decide the sequence of units based on topics, concepts, and standards.

Result: a teaching order for the year.

7

Assessments and resources

Teams brainstorm assessments and activities together, and match read-aloud books to each unit.

Result: units ready to plan in detail.